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PSYC100

Why we lie to ourselves

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: Why we lie to ourselves.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've learned, what's ahead, and how to help it stick.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Imagine this, Ron:

You tell yourself, “I really care about my health.”
It’s late, you’re tired, and you hit the drive□thru for a big greasy meal.
On the way home, you feel a bit... off. Not just full. Uncomfortable inside, like something doesn’t match.

That awkward feeling between “I value health” and “I just did the opposite” is the doorway into this lesson.

In that moment, do you think most people:

feel totally fine about the choice, or
feel at least a little tension or guilt inside?

Just answer in your own words, then we’ll build on that.

depends if you rheeath food conscious a little guilty othes dont think about it

Exactly ✸

Some people are really health□conscious, so the conflict stands out and they feel guilty. Others don’t think much about health, so there’s no real inner clash.

That inner “clash” is the key.

Let’s name it:

Cognitive dissonance = the uncomfortable tension you feel when your beliefs and your behavior don’t match.

Example:

Belief: “I’m an honest person.”
Behavior: You lie to get out of trouble.
Result: That nagging, uneasy feeling = cognitive dissonance.
Does this idea of “belief vs. behavior clash = tension” make sense so far, or should I walk through one more simple example with you?

It makes sense

Great 👍

When we feel that tension (cognitive dissonance), we usually don't just sit in it… we try to get rid of it. And we often do that by kind of "lying to ourselves" or bending our story so things match again.

Very first strategy (we'll go one at a time):

Strategy 1 – Change your behavior

Reduce the tension by acting differently next time so your actions match your belief.

Example with health:

Belief: "I care about my health."
Behavior: You ate fast food.
Next time: You pack a snack or skip the drive□thru.
You fix the mismatch by changing what you do.
Make sense that one way to reduce that inner clash is simply: "Okay, I'll act differently so it lines up with what I believe"?

Yes, that makes sense

What do you think, Ron? Take your time and pick the best option 👇

Which example shows someone reducing cognitive dissonance by changing their behavior?

A.

Alex feels bad about yelling at a coworker and decides to speak calmly next time.

B.

Jordan says, "Everyone yells sometimes, it's no big deal," and keeps yelling.

C.

Riley tells herself she never really cared about being kind in the first place.

a

Nice pick ☑

You just spotted "change behavior" in action: the person reduces the tension by deciding to act differently next time so their actions fit their belief.

Let's add a second strategy now (different way to kill that tension):

Strategy 2 – Change your belief/attitude

Instead of changing what you do, you adjust what you believe so it matches what you did.

Example with health:

Before: "Fast food is terrible; I really care about my health."

Behavior: Eats fast food late at night.
New belief: “Eh, fast food isn’t that bad once in a while; I work hard, I deserve it.”

The behavior stays, the belief softens so they don’t feel like a hypocrite.

Does this second strategy—changing your belief to match your behavior—feel clear?

Yes, it's clear

What do you think this one is, Ron? 👇

You believe “I really need to save money,” but you just bought an expensive gadget you don’t really need. To get rid of that uncomfortable feeling, you tell yourself, “Life is short, I should enjoy it. I can always save later.” What strategy is this an example of?

A.

Changing your behavior

B.

Changing your belief/attitude

C.

Ignoring the situation completely

b

Nice work again ☑

That one was about changing the belief/attitude so the person doesn’t feel bad about what they did.

We’ve seen 2 ways to reduce that inner clash:

Change behavior
Change belief/attitude

Next up is a third way: we keep both the belief and the behavior, but we add a justification story in the middle so they don’t feel like they clash.

I’ll explain that one with a simple example next. Ready to see the “excuse-making” strategy? 😄

Yes, I'm ready

Awesome 😄

Here’s the third strategy:

Strategy 3 – Add a justification (add consonant cognition)

You keep the belief and the behavior, but you add extra thoughts to make them seem consistent.

Health example:

Belief: “I care about my health.”
Behavior: Late□night fast food.

Justifications:
“It was a crazy day; I needed comfort food.”
“I usually eat well, so this doesn’t really count.”
“I’ll work out extra tomorrow.”

Nothing actually changed yet — just the story around it.

Does this “excuse□making / justification” strategy feel clear in your own words?

Yes, I think so

What do you think fits best here, Ron? 👇

Ron buys an expensive pair of shoes even though he believes he should be saving money. Later he tells himself: “These shoes will last for years, so really I’m saving in the long run.” What strategy is he using to reduce his cognitive dissonance?

A.

Change his behavior (return the shoes and stop buying expensive things)

B.

Change his belief (decide that saving money isn’t that important after all)

C.

Add justifications to make the purchase seem reasonable

D.

Trivialize it by telling himself, “Money doesn’t matter at all”

c

Exactly 🎯

That’s the justification / adding extra reasons strategy: “I still believe X, I still did Y, but here’s why it’s actually okay…”

So far we’ve got 3 ways to reduce cognitive dissonance:

Change behavior
Change belief/attitude
Add justifications/excuses

There’s one more big one:

Strategy 4 – Trivialize it

You tell yourself the conflict is no big deal or not important.

Example:

Belief: “Health matters.”
Behavior: Eats fast food.
Trivializing thoughts:
“Life’s short, who cares.”
“Everyone does this.”
“It’s just food, not a big thing.”

You shrink the importance so the clash doesn’t feel worth worrying about.

Does this idea of trivializing the conflict (making it seem unimportant) make sense to you?

Yes, that makes sense

What do you think fits best here, Ron? 👇

Ron reads this:

"I know smoking is bad for my health, but honestly, everyone has to die of something. It’s not worth stressing over."

What dissonance strategy is this most clearly an example of?

A.

Changing behavior to match the belief

B.

Changing the belief/attitude about smoking

C.

Adding justifications to make smoking seem reasonable

D.

Trivializing the importance of the health risk

d

Nice job, Ron ☑

You’ve now seen the four main ways people reduce cognitive dissonance:

Change behavior
Change belief/attitude
Add justifications
Trivialize the conflict

Now I want to show you one special case that’s really common in real life: effort justification.

Simple version:

When we work really hard for something, we tend to convince ourselves it’s more valuable or better than it might actually be — so all that effort feels “worth it.”

Example:

Someone spends weeks doing a miserable, boring training just to join a group.
When they finally get in, they tell themselves:
“This group is amazing; it’s totally worth it.”
(Even if the group is… kind of average.)

That story reduces dissonance: “I suffered a lot” vs. “Maybe it wasn’t worth it” turns into “It was worth it.”

Can you think of any time (school, work, hobby, purchase) where you put in a lot of effort and then found yourself talking it up more, maybe partly to make the effort feel worth it?

not off hand

No problem at all — we can build one together 👍

Let’s use a simple, concrete example: buying something expensive.

Imagine this:

You spend a whole weekend assembling complicated furniture (lots of parts, frustrating instructions).
The final result is… okay. Not amazing.
But you catch yourself thinking and saying:
“This is actually really great quality.”
“I like this more than the one that comes pre□built.”
“Doing it myself makes it better.”

That’s effort justification: “If I worked this hard, it must be worth it.”

Quick check: if someone goes through a very hard process to join a club, then later says the club is amazing (partly so the effort feels worth it), what is that called?

You can just answer in words like: “effort justification” or “something else” — what do you think?

effort justification

Exactly — that’s effort justification 🎯

“I went through a lot for this, so it must be good.”

One last key idea for this lesson:

Selective exposure = when we look for info that supports what we already did/believe, and avoid info that would make us feel that dissonance.

Example:

You buy an expensive gadget.
After buying it, you:
Read only positive reviews.
Avoid videos titled “Why this gadget is a waste of money.” This helps you feel, “I made the right choice,” instead of, “Uh oh, maybe I messed up.”
I want to check the whole pattern now.

If you:

do something that conflicts with your belief,
feel tension,
then change your belief, behavior, or story to reduce that tension…

How would you describe what cognitive dissonance is, in your own words? (Short and simple is perfect.)

it is trying to resolve your inner conflict for acting against your beliefs by planniing

to do beter next time,, beliitle the conflict or change the narrative

That’s a strong explanation, Ron 👍

Let me tighten it just a bit using your own ideas:

Cognitive dissonance is the uncomfortable inner conflict you feel when your behavior doesn’t match your beliefs — and then you reduce that conflict by planning to do better, belittling the conflict, or changing the story you tell yourself.

That’s exactly what Festinger was talking about.

Before we wrap this lesson up, one more connection:

In the last lesson you saw how situations (like groups, pressure, bystanders) can push people to act a certain way.

After that action, inside the person, cognitive dissonance can kick in:

“I’m a good person” vs. “I didn’t help”
Then they explain it away, change their story, or decide “it wasn’t my responsibility.”
From your point of view:

Do you feel like you could now spot when someone (including you) is reducing dissonance by:

changing behavior,
changing beliefs,
adding justifications, or
trivializing the conflict?

If yes, I’d say you’ve mastered this lesson — and we can move on when you’re ready.

I think so

You’ve got it, Ron 🎯

You can now:

Explain cognitive dissonance in your own words
Recognize how people reduce it by:
changing behavior (“I’ll do better next time”)
changing beliefs (“It’s not really that bad”)
adding justifications (“I had no choice, it was a tough day”)
trivializing (“It’s not a big deal, everyone does it”)
Understand effort justification and selective exposure as special ways we protect ourselves from that inner clash
This is a big piece of how our mind protects our self-image.

When you’re back in the Learn tab, you can jump into the next lesson in General Psychology.
If you’d like, I can also help you apply this idea to work, relationships, or decision-making next time.